

Polymer An organic molecule made from many identical units joined together. Plastics are an example of polymers.

Prehistoric A way of describing a time before there were written records.

Probe An unmanned, robotic spacecraft controlled and monitored from Earth. A space probe may approach the moon, land on a planet or comet, or travel out of the solar system.

Propeller A device with blades that is attached to a boat or an aircraft. The engine makes the propeller spin around and causes the boat or aircraft to move.

Proton A particle inside an atom that has a positive electric charge. The number of protons in an atom determines its chemical properties.

Prow The front part of a ship.

Radiation The process by which heat transfers through air or an empty space.

Radioactive A material in which the nucleus of each atom is unstable and breaks apart, releasing high-energy particles in the form of nuclear radiation.

Renewable energy A type of energy that will not run out, and is generated from sources such as the sun, wind, and water.

Resistor An electronic component that reduces the electric current flowing through a circuit.

Saltpeter This is another name for the compound potassium nitrate. Saltpeter is an active ingredient in many things, from fertilizers to fireworks.

Satellite An object in space that travels around another object in a path called an orbit. Scientists have sent artificial satellites into Earth's orbit to take photographs, transmit data, and help people navigate on Earth.

Semaphore An early system of signaling that is used to communicate information from a distance. The position of two pivoting arms or blades represents different letters or numbers.

Semiconductor A substance used in electronics that has the ability to switch from being an insulator that blocks electricity to a conductor that carries it.

Smelting The process of extracting metal from its ore.

Solar A way of describing something that is related to, or caused by, the sun.

Solar system The sun and all the planets, moons, and other celestial bodies that go around the sun.

Spacecraft Vehicles used to explore the solar system.

Steel A hard, strong metal made from iron and small amounts of carbon. Steel is widely used in construction, from making skyscrapers to bridges.

Sumerian A way of describing something that relates to the ancient Mesopotamian (present-day Iraq) civilization of Sumer, or the Sumerian language.

Synthetic Another word for artificial.

Thrust A push or a force. When something pushes or accelerates in one direction there is a force (thrust) just as large in the opposite direction.

Torque A force that makes an object turn.

Transistor A semiconductor device made of crystals of silicon mixed with tiny amounts of other elements that alter its electrical properties. The result is a device that can control the flow of electrical current very precisely.

Turbine A machine designed to produce continuous power. It includes a wheel or rotor that turns fast due to the flow of water, steam, or gas that goes over it.

Vacuum An empty space that contains no air or material of any kind.

Virus An infectious particle that is much smaller than bacteria and is responsible for lots of different diseases.

▼ *FOUR STAR-TRACKING LASER BEAMS EMERGE FROM A TELESCOPE AT THE PARANAL OBSERVATORY IN CHILE*

